Know Your Local Hazards

Research the hazards that could affect the places you use, record the official instruction for each one, and recheck it regularly.

! WARNING — URGENT ACTION

During an emergency, current instructions from local authorities take priority over this worksheet. General preparedness guidance helps you plan; it does not set local evacuation zones, routes, shelter locations, alert thresholds, or re-entry rules.

1. LIST THE PLACES TO CHECK

Place	Address or route	People, animals, access, or transport needs
Home		
Workplace(s)		
School / care site		
Common travel routes		

2. ASK OFFICIAL SOURCES

- ☐ **Local emergency management:** ask which hazards affect each place, who can order evacuation or sheltering, and where official zone and route information is published.
- ☐ **Official alerting services:** enroll every household member who can receive alerts; note coverage, languages, accessibility features, and a backup method. Wireless Emergency Alerts require no sign-up, but local opt-in systems may.
- ☐ **Map owners:** check official evacuation-zone maps and, where applicable, flood, fire, earthquake, tsunami, dam, landslide, severe-weather, or other hazard maps. Record the map issuer, layer, and date—not only a screenshot.
- ☐ **Workplaces, schools, and care sites:** request their emergency, reunification, closure, and transportation procedures.
- ☐ **Utility providers:** ask about hazard-specific shutoffs, outage alerts, safe service interruption, medical-equipment programs, and restoration information.
- ☐ **Insurance and property records:** review declarations, exclusions, deductibles, inventories, surveys, disclosures, permits, and assessor or recorder documents. Ask the insurer or record holder to explain unclear entries.

Map caution: a map may describe one hazard or planning purpose only. Do not treat an insurance, parcel, or risk map as an evacuation order. Confirm its purpose with the issuing authority.

Know Your Local Hazards — continued

Use one record for every hazard at every place it affects. Duplicate these pages when needed.

HAZARD RECORD A

Hazard		**Places affected**	☐ Home ☐ Work ☐ School/care ☐ Routes
Warning signs I may observe			
Official alert source	Agency, service/channel, sign-up or access method:		
Protective action	What the issuing authority says to do:		
Evacuate or shelter trigger	Exact official term, level, zone, boundary, or condition—and who issues it:		
Seasonal timing	Likely period, lead time, and conditions (or “year-round”):		
Household-specific complications	Mobility, medical/power, communication, transport, children, animals, language, or route limits:		
Information verified	Date: _____	**Verified with**	Agency/record and URL, office, or document ID: _____

Know Your Local Hazards — continued

HAZARD RECORD B

Hazard		**Places affected**	☐ Home ☐ Work ☐ School/care ☐ Routes
Warning signs I may observe			
Official alert source	Agency, service/channel, sign-up or access method:		
Protective action	What the issuing authority says to do:		
Evacuate or shelter trigger	Exact official term, level, zone, boundary, or condition—and who issues it:		
Seasonal timing	Likely period, lead time, and conditions (or “year-round”):		
Household-specific complications	Mobility, medical/power, communication, transport, children, animals, language, or route limits:		
Information verified	Date: _____	**Verified with**	Agency/record and URL, office, or document ID: _____

Know Your Local Hazards — continued

Record what an official source says, not what a neighbor, social post, or unlabeled map assumes.

HAZARD RECORD C

Hazard		**Places affected**	☐ Home ☐ Work ☐ School/care ☐ Routes
Warning signs I may observe			
Official alert source	Agency, service/channel, sign-up or access method:		
Protective action	What the issuing authority says to do:		
Evacuate or shelter trigger	Exact official term, level, zone, boundary, or condition—and who issues it:		
Seasonal timing	Likely period, lead time, and conditions (or “year-round”):		
Household-specific complications	Mobility, medical/power, communication, transport, children, animals, language, or route limits:		
Information verified	Date: _____	**Verified with**	Agency/record and URL, office, or document ID: _____

Know Your Local Hazards — continued

HAZARD RECORD D

Hazard		**Places affected**	☐ Home ☐ Work ☐ School/care ☐ Routes
Warning signs I may observe			
Official alert source	Agency, service/channel, sign-up or access method:		
Protective action	What the issuing authority says to do:		
Evacuate or shelter trigger	Exact official term, level, zone, boundary, or condition—and who issues it:		
Seasonal timing	Likely period, lead time, and conditions (or “year-round”):		
Household-specific complications	Mobility, medical/power, communication, transport, children, animals, language, or route limits:		
Information verified	Date: _____	**Verified with**	Agency/record and URL, office, or document ID: _____

Know Your Local Hazards — continued

Finish the local blanks, compare hazards across places, and carry the results into your plans.

LOCAL DETAILS STILL TO RESOLVE

◎ LOCAL INFORMATION — VERIFY BEFORE APPROVAL

[VERIFY] Local emergency-management authority: _____

[VERIFY] Official local alert service and enrollment page/number: _____

[VERIFY] Evacuation-zone map issuer, URL/office, and my zone(s):

_____

[VERIFY] Locally applicable flood/fire/earthquake or other map(s): _____

[VERIFY] Utility emergency/outage sources: _____

[VERIFY] Workplace, school/care, and route authorities: _____

[VERIFY] Insurance contact and relevant property-record office:

_____

Verified by: _____ **Date:** _____ **Next review:** _____

TURN RESEARCH INTO ACTION

- ☐ Compare hazards across home, work, school/care, and routes; identify alternatives where one event could affect several places.
- ☐ Save official sources on phones and on paper. Keep a battery-radio or other backup method appropriate to local guidance.
- ☐ Write zone names and triggers into the household plan; do not preselect a route that officials may close.
- ☐ Discuss assistance, transport, medicines, power, communication, and animal needs before an alert.
- ☐ Review after a move, school/job/route change, insurance renewal, map revision, major incident, or official guidance update—and at least annually.

Know Your Local Hazards — continued

BINDER FOLLOW-THROUGH

Section 7 — Hazard Guides: use the guide for each hazard you identify to learn protective actions and hazard-specific supplies. Confirm every locally controlled trigger, zone, and instruction with its issuing authority.

Section 8 — Plans & Records: transfer verified alerts, contacts, meeting places, evacuation/shelter decisions, access needs, insurance information, inventories, and review dates into the household plan and protected records.

SOURCES

General preparedness and alerting: Ready.gov, “Be Informed” and “Alerts and Warnings”; FEMA, “Integrated Public Alert & Warning System for the American People”; and USA.gov, “State Emergency Management Agencies.” Mapping: FEMA, “Flood Maps”; U.S. Geological Survey, “Earthquake Hazards Program”; and U.S. Department of Agriculture Forest Service, “Wildfire Risk to Communities.” Records: National Association of Insurance Commissioners, “Disaster Preparedness.” All accessed September 25, 2026. Local instructions must be supplied and verified by the responsible local authority.